which females store sperm for life. In the case of ants, bees, and wasps there is, as Chapter 10 discusses, a special genetic peculiarity—haplodiploidy—that may have predisposed them to become highly social. What I am arguing here is that haplodiploidy is not the only predisposing factor. The habit of lifetime sperm-storage may have been at least as important. Under ideal conditions it can make a mother as genetically valuable, and as worthy of 'altruistic' help, as an identical twin.

p. 138* … *social anthropologists might have interesting things to say.

This remark now makes me blush with embarrassment. I have since learned that social anthropologists not only have things to say about the 'mother's brother effect': many of them have for years spoken of little else! The effect that I 'predicted' is an empirical fact in a large number of cultures that has been well known to anthropologists for decades. Moreover, when I suggested the specific hypothesis that 'in a society with a high degree of marital infidelity, maternal uncles should be more altruistic than "fathers", since they have more grounds for confidence in their relatedness to the child' (p. 138), I regrettably overlooked the fact that Richard Alexander had already made the same suggestion (a footnote acknowledging this was inserted in later printings of the first edition of this book). The hypothesis has been tested, by Alexander himself among others, using quantitative counts from the anthropological literature, with favourable results.